MARCHING TO ITS OWN DRUMBEAT

Beyond the social media humour, Pakistanis are open to better relations with India. But jingoism and bullying from across the border don't elicit ideas of friendship

By **HASAN ZAIDI** *in Karachi*

AFP

IF anyone needed contemporary evidence for the two-nation theory, they could have pointed to the social media of Pakistan and India in the aftermath of the horrendous Pahalgam attack. In fact, Indians and Pakistanis seemed to exist in different worlds in cyberspace. Whereas Indian social media seemed to be breathing fire after the initial shock—in line with the immediate blame levelled by India against Pakistan—Pakistani social media responded to the threat of doom in the way it knows best: with memes and humour.

When an Indian tweeted that missiles should be launched on Lahore, Muridke and Rawalpindi—cities in Pakistani Punjab—one wag commented that even when it came to missiles, Punjab was gobbling up the rights of other provinces. When another Indian claimed the problem was not Pakistan but Pakistanis living in India, a Pakistani responded with mock incredulity, "No way you're trying to pin this on Adnan Sami???"

Wit: The Best Defence

When India announced it was suspending the Indus Waters Treaty, a slew of memes poured forth, such as one with a man taking a shower calling on India to turn the water on again because soap was getting into his eyes. Others were self-deprecating, such as one Pakistani telling India to start the war before 9 pm because gas 'loadshedding' begins at 9.15 pm, and some warning Indian soldiers to leave their mobile phones at home because they'd get snatched on Karachi's streets. One commented that if India captured Lahore, it would want to give it back within two hours! Others used stills and videos from Bollywood films to mock the heated rhetoric from Indian TV channels.

One of the funniest posts referenced the national cricket teams playing each other only at neutral venues. "*Guys war bhi hybrid model pe Dubai mein hogi ya India iss baar Pakistan aa raha hai* (Guys, will the war also be fought on a hybrid model in Dubai or will India come to Pakistan this time?)" asked @aymx_infinity on X.

Observers were stumped, trying to understand why Pakistani social media was taking the threat of war so

THE THREAT OF A POTENTIAL INDIAN INGRESS INTO PAKISTAN HAS MADE THE SQUABBLING POLITICAL OPPOSITION CLOSE RANKS BEHIND THE ESTABLISHMENT